

"A nation's strength ultimately consists in what it

## Indira Gandhi

Former prime minister 1917-1984

# TRIUMPH OF WILL

Was she a transition figure, a bridge between the India her father left and the one that came into being after her death in 1984? The jury is out but her legacies, both good and bad, remain.

■ By Dipesh Chakrabarty

In many ways, she was and she was not. She was perhaps the most populist prime minister we have had so far, who expanded the role of the government in public life and ruled through a mixture of populist anti-poverty and anti-West rhetoric and a certain strategic alliance, internally, with the Indian Left and, externally, with the Soviet Union. She took to an extreme what were once the Leftist and anti-imperialist tenets in Nehru's policies. But it is significant that once she was gone, India—even under her son Rajiv—changed course quite radically and started opening up to the West. The broad consensus about liberalising and globalising the Indian economy that has underlain both BJP and Congress-led coalitions in Delhi in the last decade or so, marks, if anything, a complete departure from Indira Gandhi's policies and worldview. She was not the middle ground, as it were, between Nehru's "socialistic" and today's "globalised" India. If anything, she belonged to a period that did not act as a corridor connecting the present to the past and the future. It was a period that stood at an angle to both what came before and after. Indira was, globally speaking, a part of the last phase of the Cold War, when that war was at its 'coldest', representing two sides of a sharply-drawn but frozen border with little or no room for any middle ground in global politics, such as the one that the Non-Aligned Movement

of the 1950s once signified.

But it is not that nothing of the house that Indira built survives today. The dynastic element is still very much there in our politics. The kind of corruption that was enabled by the larger intrusion of the state into the economy—bank nationalisation, for example—only seems to have increased under later dispensations. The small-savings and tax-avoidance schemes that Indira introduced to stabilise and subsidise the lives of the middle classes—and thus co-opt them into the ruling compact—appear to have become an enduring feature of the political-economic scene that politicians can ignore only at their own peril. CPI(M) and CPI in Delhi still exist and operate as a rump of the past, their elites dreaming of returning to Indira's days (while the CPI(M) units in the states appear to be reciting globalisation mantras).

On some other fronts too, her legacies, both good and bad, continue to be influential. The Congress as a party has never recovered from the blow it received from her. Her tendency to concentrate power in her own hands within the party and to mow down all regional bosses surely helped to produce a Congress party bereft of any federal or democratic process or spirit infusing its organisational machinery. But the very creation and functioning of Bangladesh remains a testimony to the leadership she provided the region at a time of serious political crisis. Her capacity to

stand up to the Americans, her backing of the Green Revolution (though not an unproblematic achievement), and her emphasis on sovereignty in space, military, and scientific research have definitely stood the country in good stead.

She was, as many have said, deeply contradictory in her personality and faith. The Emergency itself brought out some of these contradictions. She will no doubt be remembered and resented for imposing the only Emergency and suspension of democratic rights that Indians have suffered since Independence. But her voluntary decision to end the Emergency and face the electorate (and be defeated) in 1977 completely confounded and proved wrong all those experts who had proclaimed the Emergency to be the final burial of a democracy that they had long judged 'dead'. There was no doubting her deep sense of patriotism or her commitment to the nation as a whole. It is, after all, a profoundly moving fact that, even after she had been advised of the risks involved, she refused to bar Sikhs from employment in her personal security staff (unless there was concrete evidence against them) on the ground that she was their prime minister too. That she died of this risk that she knowingly took speaks volumes of the heroic courage and commitments of this complex but remarkable person.

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